began to create coalitions with more established parts of the software production and distribution sector. New companies and organisations were founded, while new products, licences and communities were created.

In the spring of 1997, a group of leaders in the free software community assembled in California. This group included Eric Raymond, Tim O'Reilly, and VA Research president Larry Augustin, among others. Their concern was to find a way to promote the ideas surrounding free software among people who had formerly shunned the concept. They were concerned that the Free Software Foundation's anti-business message was keeping the world at large from really appreciating the power of free software. At Eric Raymond's insistence, the group agreed that what they lacked to a great extent was a marketing campaign devised to win mindshare, and not just market share. Out of this discussion came a new term to describe the software they were promoting: open source. A series of guidelines were crafted to describe software that qualified as open source. While there has been a hacker subculture developing open source applications and Internet protocols for many years, without explicitly using the label 'open source', it is only in the last few years, after this conference, that this practice has become visible to a broader public.

In 1998, Microsoft's anxiety leaked out through what is now known as the Halloween Documents. These documents comprised a series of confidential Microsoft memos on potential strategies relating to free software, open source software, and to Linux in particular. Among the leaked documents were a series of responses to the original memos. The leaked documents and responses were published by Eric Raymond during Halloween 1998. Forced to concede that the memos did indeed originate from within the company, Microsoft dismissed them as the private speculations of a couple of engineers. "Linux has been deployed in mission-critical, commercial environments with an excellent pool of public testimonials," Vinod Valloppillil, one of the memos' authors, had noted. The documents also acknowledged that open source software "…is long-term credible ... FUD (spreading Fear, Uncertainty, and Doubt) tactics cannot be used to combat it," and "Recent case studies (the Internet) provide very dramatic evidence ... that commercial quality can be achieved / exceeded by OSS projects." FUD was a traditional Microsoft marketing strategy, acknowledged and understood internally. Examples of Microsoft's FUD tactics included announcing the launch of non-existent products or spreading rumours that competing products would cause Windows to crash.

So, who are these hackers?

Should you happen to bump into them and inquire about their craft, hackers will gleefully inform you that programming is the most fun you can have with your clothes on... although clothes are not mandatory.

A hacker is someone who enjoys exploring the details of computers and how to stretch their capabilities, as opposed to most users, who prefer to learn the minimum necessary. Originally, 'hacker' was a term of respect, used among computer programmers, designers, and engineers. The hacker was one who created original and ingenious programs. To programmers, 'hackers' connote mastery in the most literal sense: those who can make a computer do what they want it to—whether the computer wants to or not. Unfortunately, this term has been abused by the media to give it a negative connotation—of someone who breaks into systems, destroys data, steals copyrighted software and performs other destructive or illegal acts with computers and networks. The term that accurately defines that kind of person is 'cracker'.

Hackers carry stacks of ideas teetering in their heads at any given time. Their brains cannot stop collecting, consuming, or taking things apart, only to reassemble them again. But what seems to drive them is an intense ability, even a need, for analysis and organisation. When hackers encounter a technology for the first time, they do not just absorb the general shape, but go straight for the details. They feed on the logic of technology. When they do communicate, they can speak and write with great precision about what they've learned.

The hacker attitude

Hackers solve problems and build things, and they believe in freedom and voluntary mutual help. The hacker mindset is not confined to the realm of software (or hardware). The hacker nature is independent of the particular medium the hacker works in. Hackerism ideas have travelled beyond the computer industry. The ideals of the hacker culture could apply to almost any activity one pursues with passion. Burrell Smith, a key member of the team that created the Apple Macintosh computer, says, "Hackers can do almost anything and be a hacker. You can be a hacker carpenter. It's not necessarily high-tech. I think it has to do with craftsmanship, and caring about what you're doing."

In his book 'Biopunk', Marcus Wohlsen reasons that the primal urge to tinker is an essential prerequisite to being a hacker. In the hands of its most gifted practitioners, tinkering is an essential form of creativity. But it is a different brand of creativity, practised in a different spirit, than the kind suggested by the romantic image of the lone artist or genius inventor trying to wrestle inspiration out of nothing.

Tinkering in a generic sense is fiddling or tweaking, spending the weekend in the garage trying to squeeze a few more horsepower out of the Yamaha FZ 16. But it still retains the idea of 'work that is not really work'. Jacking up your shocks and putting in balloon tyres on your Willy's Jeep is